privilege one particular culture. Akbar understood this through his sulh kul, through his refusal to be claimed by one certitude and one truth. If we are to visit our rich past to understand our complicated present, then Akbar's is a life worth studying.

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Akbar's tomb is enigmatic, complicated, and unfinished, somewhat like the emperor's legacy itself. Originally built along the banks of the Yamuna, there is no clear consensus on when exactly the tomb was begun, or who the patron was. Scholars now agree that it may have been started by Akbar himself, towards the end of his reign, then partly broken down, redesigned, built, and left unfinished by Jahangir reflecting, also, the twisted and entwined destinies of the two men.

The main gateway leading to the tomb complex is a towering structure in red sandstone entirely covered in geometrical patterns in white marble, black slate, and coloured stones. There would have been clerics housed in the rooms within the enormous gateway, quietly murmuring endless prayers for the soul of the Padshah. At the top of the gateway is a naqqar khana, where drumbeats would have marked the rising and the setting of the sun. In contemporary sources the mausoleum was called Bihistabad (Abode of Paradise) and that theme was reflected in its paradisiacal charbagh structure with four canals running beneath the mausoleum. Laura E. Parodi showed that the paradisiacal motif was reflected in the symbology of the decorations used in the structure: '…cypress and fruit trees standing for immortality and the abundance of fruit promised to the believers; bottles alluding to the purified wine drunk by paradise-dwellers; birds like the peacock (the Paradise bird par excellence) and parakeet'. Even today, after 400 years of indifferent care, the entrance vault glows with the ochres, blues and gold of the swaying leaves in the hazy afternoon sun. The last line of the verses inscribed on the gateway reads:

These are the gardens of Eden, enter them to live for ever.

In many ways, however, the numerous layers and textures of styles make the monument almost impossible to define. There is the sprawling, horizontal spread of the mausoleum, the repeating chattri elements, the jaalis, the palace-like appearance of the tomb as it rises up in a stepped pattern, the elaborate decorations, and the horizontal trabeated lines that have scholars scrambling for precedents and allusions from the Panch